

THE BUYER'S GUIDE

An Insider's Guide to Buying Your Home in *San Francisco*

*A teach-first walk-through of how buying actually works here —
the search, the offers, the paperwork, and the keys in your hand.*

claudia lee

What's *inside*.

Eleven short chapters, in roughly the order they'll actually happen. Skip around if you like — but if you read only three, make them *getting your money right*, *the disclosure package*, and *what buying actually costs*. Those are where smart decisions are quietly made.

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No hard sell. Just an open door.

First, and *foremost.*

You're about to buy what's probably the biggest purchase of your life, in one of the most competitive markets in the country. How you go about it matters — so thank you for letting me walk you through it.

I made this guide because I teach first. Before we ever talk offer strategy or open-house schedules, I want you to actually understand the moves in front of you — a buyer who gets the process makes calmer, smarter decisions, and calm decisions are what protect your money.

So this isn't a pitch. It's the plain-English version of everything I wish every buyer knew before they started looking: how SF's market really works, what a disclosure package actually tells you, what makes an offer win, and what buying costs when the dust settles.

Read it at your own pace. There's no clock running, and there's no pressure from me. When you're ready to talk about your specific search, I'll be right here.

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"My job isn't to get you a house. It's to guide you to make empowered, educated decisions that match your lifestyle and your priorities. The right home, the right way."

— claudia

WHO I AM, BRIEFLY

An SF REALTOR® at Vantage, running the *Claudia Insider* brand on one idea: real estate should be taught, not sold. I bring the branding, marketing, and tech side of a modern home search — backed by a hyper-local team with deep SF experience. A little more on both of us, next page.

Fun fact — I'm a 3× US national team member and multiple-time national karate champion. Turns out staying calm under pressure is a very transferable skill.

Have a question — any question? I mean it. Reach out anytime, no commitment required.

WHO'S IN YOUR CORNER

A hyper-local team, and a *human* to run it.

You're not hiring one person — you're getting a boutique San Francisco firm behind you, and an agent who genuinely loves the education side of this. Here's the pairing that goes to work on your search.

THE TEAM — YOUR SUPPORT

Vantage agents are **hyper-local**. We read the city's micromarkets and its seasonality block by block — not "San Francisco" as one market, but your corner of it, this time of year. The team carries real tenure and standing in the SF real estate community, which is exactly the muscle you want behind your negotiation and your offer strategy.

And Vantage runs on **Side** — the platform powering a top-tier national network — so a boutique, personal experience comes with serious tools, marketing, and legal support underneath.



WHAT I BRING — YOUR LEAD

- **Education-first approach** — I train you to read disclosures, understand comps, and evaluate a home before your money is on the line.
- **Branding & market sense** — I study this market every day. That obsession works for you when we're writing offers.
- **A human to work with** — I keep it collaborative, clear, and low-stress, whether we're touring or navigating escrow.

THE VANTAGE TEAM · REALTRENDS VERIFIED, 2025

#1

SF LARGE TEAM,
AVG. SALE PRICE

#3

SF LARGE TEAM,
BY SALES VOLUME

\$600M+

SOLD SINCE
FOUNDING, 2023

\$230M+

VOLUME
YEAR-TO-DATE

Top 0.1%

IN CA & U.S.,
REALTRENDS

Local team muscle, plus an education-first agent who keeps it human. That's the combination working for you.

YOUR CORNER

It moves fast here. And that's *by design*.

If you've shopped for a home anywhere else, forget most of it. San Francisco has its own rhythm, and understanding it before you walk into your first open house is the single best thing you can do for yourself.

Here's something that catches almost every buyer off guard: **in SF, the list price is often a marketing strategy, not a value statement.** List price, market value, and sale price are three different numbers. Most desirable homes — especially single-family houses — are priced below what they're expected to sell for. The seller sets an offer date, usually about a week after listing, and buyers compete. A home listed at \$1.4M might sell for \$1.65M because ten prepared buyers showed up on offer day.

I know that can feel frustrating — especially if you've already been outbid once or twice. That frustration is completely valid, and I want you to know I get it. But here's what most people miss: **preparation beats speed.** The buyers who win aren't the ones who panic-bid the highest number. They're the ones who reviewed the disclosures early, had their financing locked, and wrote a clean offer with terms the seller could trust. That's what we'll build toward together.

Not every home sells this way. Condos, higher price points, and softer pockets often price transparently and negotiate more traditionally. I'll tell you which game we're playing for each home — because the strategy changes with the property.



THE BUYER-BROKER AGREEMENT

Before we officially work together, we'll sign a **Buyer-Broker Representation Agreement** (the BRBC). It spells out how I represent you, what my compensation looks like, and what you can expect. I'll walk you through every line — no surprises.

WHAT I'LL BRING YOU

A real read on how homes are priced in your target neighborhoods — what's selling fast, what's sitting, and where list-to-sale gaps land. I'll map it out for each home so you're never guessing.

The buyers who do best in this market aren't the ones with the most money. They're the ones who showed up the most prepared.

This is the move that makes everything else *work*.

Before we tour a single home, I need to know — and you need to know — exactly where you stand financially. Not a rough idea. Not a Zillow calculator. A real, verified number from a real lender. This is the single biggest thing you can do to be ready.

PRE-APPROVED VS. FULLY UNDERWRITTEN

- **Pre-qualified** — a quick estimate based on what you told the lender. It's a starting point, but it doesn't carry weight in an offer.
- **Pre-approved** — the lender has verified your income, assets, and credit. This is the minimum to be taken seriously. Get here before we tour.
- **Fully underwritten** — the lender has done nearly everything except tie it to a specific property. In a competitive offer, this is the gold card. It tells the seller your loan is as close to a sure thing as it gets.

TALK TO MORE THAN ONE LENDER

You're allowed to shop. I'll introduce you to a few loan agents I trust — and I like to give you **three** so you can compare rates, fees, and communication styles. Pick the one who explains things in a way that clicks for you.

WHY FINANCING STRENGTH WINS OFFERS

In a multiple-offer situation, the seller isn't just looking at the highest number. They're looking at **which buyer is most likely to actually close**. A fully underwritten buyer at \$1.55M can beat an uncertain pre-qual at \$1.6M, because the seller trusts the deal will hold.

All-cash removes the loan question entirely — but most buyers aren't all-cash, and that's completely fine. Strong conventional financing with a solid down payment and clean pre-approval is how most SF homes close.

PROOF OF FUNDS

When we write an offer, you'll need to show proof of your down payment and closing costs — a bank or brokerage statement, usually. Have it ready before we need it so there's no scrambling on offer day.

BUDGET VS. PAYMENT

Your lender will tell you the maximum you *qualify* for. That's not necessarily what you should spend. I'd rather you buy a home that fits your life than one that maxes your approval. We'll talk about the real monthly number — principal, interest, tax, insurance, HOA — not just the sticker price.

Tour with your eyes open, not your *heart* racing.

—

This is the fun part — and the part where knowing what to look for saves you from confusing house #3 with house #9. I take copious notes, keep a spreadsheet of every home we see, and teach you to read a property the way I do.

TOURING LIKE AN INVESTIGATOR

- **Start outside** — look at the foundation, the roof line, the grading. Water and the hill it sits on tell you more than the kitchen.
- **Check the bones** — electrical panel age, plumbing material, window condition, any signs of water intrusion. These are where the real costs hide.
- **Feel the layout** — does the flow work for your actual life? Not the staged version, your Tuesday-night version.
- **Watch the light** — afternoon light, not noon light. Anything looks bright at noon.
- **Trust your gut** — "something about it bugged me" is real data. Tell me, even if you can't explain it.

PROPERTY TYPES IN SF

San Francisco's housing stock is unusual — single-family homes are only about a quarter of it, which is exactly why they command a premium. The rest is condos, TICs (tenancies in common), and multi-unit buildings, and each one comes with different financing, different ownership structures, and different things to watch for.

I have a separate resource guide — *Condo vs. TIC: What Every SF Buyer Should Know* — that breaks down the differences side by side: ownership, financing, typical costs, and what I look at for you as your agent. Ask me for it anytime.

I WATCH WHAT YOU DON'T SEE

I'm tracking TAN (Top Agent Network) posts, coming-soon listings, expired and canceled listings — sometimes the right home is one that fell out of contract or hasn't hit the open market yet. I'll also send you recent nearby sales so you learn this market by watching it, not by taking my word for it.

Know your non-negotiables and your dealbreakers before you tour. Rarely is there a perfect home — but there is a right one.

The home's *baggage* — and how to read it.

Every SF home comes to market with a fat stack of disclosures and reports. It looks intimidating the first time you open one — sometimes 200+ pages. But this is where the real story of a home lives, and I'll teach you how to read it. Think of this chapter as a syllabus — the actual training happens when we sit down together with a real package in front of us.

WHAT'S IN THE PACKAGE

- **Seller disclosures (TDS + SF supplemental)** — what the seller knows about the home's condition, history, and any issues. The more they share, the better for you.
- **Preliminary title report** — who's on title, any liens or easements, and anything recorded against the property. Your title company will walk through this, and so will I.
- **The 3R Report** — San Francisco's Report of Residential Building Record. This is the permit history — it tells you what work was done legally and what might not have been. It's a city record, not an inspection.
- **Natural Hazard report (NHD)** — flood zones, fire zones, seismic and fault zones. Ordered from a third party.

THE INSPECTIONS

- **General / property inspection** — the whole-home checkup. In SF, the seller commonly has this done before listing so buyers can review it upfront.
- **Pest inspection (WDO)** — Section 1 is active damage or infestation; Section 2 is conditions that *could* lead to problems. Pay attention to both.
- **Agent visual inspection (AVID)** — the listing agent's written observations of the property, room by room.
- **Sometimes:** a sewer lateral scope, roof report, or foundation report, depending on the home's age and condition.

THIS IS MY THING

I will personally walk you through your disclosure package and translate every scary-sounding line into plain English. You don't need to be an expert — that's literally my job. But by the time we write an offer, you'll understand exactly what you're buying.

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The strongest offer isn't always the *highest*.

Short phase, high stakes. This is where the preparation from every chapter before pays off. Here's how offers actually work in San Francisco — and what we control to make yours competitive.

HOW IT WORKS HERE

- **Highest and best** — the most common practice when submitting a first offer in SF. You bring your strongest number and your cleanest terms, because you may not get a second chance. But every situation calls for a different strategy, and I'll map the right one to each home.
- **Earnest money** — your good-faith deposit, commonly around 3% of the purchase price, wired within about a day of acceptance. A bigger deposit signals you're serious and low-risk.
- **Contingencies** — think of each one (inspection, appraisal, loan) as a door you can walk back out of. In competitive offers, buyers often waive them after thoroughly reviewing the seller's pre-sale package. We'll never waive anything you're not comfortable with.

WHAT MAKES YOUR OFFER STAND OUT

- **Financing strength** — fully underwritten beats pre-approved; all-cash removes the appraisal question. This is chapter 04 paying off.
- **Clean terms & few contingencies** — fewer exits for you means more certainty for the seller that the deal will actually close.
- **Close date that works** — and whether you can offer a rent-back if the seller needs time to move out.
- **Deposit size** — real money down, quickly, is a real signal of commitment.

ON OFFER STRATEGY

I pull comps and build the case for a number that's competitive *and* makes sense for you. Before we write, we'll decide your true ceiling and your walk-away point — and hold both. I'll walk you through terms, timing, and strategy for each specific home, because the right play changes every time.

Offer with confidence and clarity upfront — no buyer's remorse after. That starts with knowing your ceiling, your walk-away, and trusting the preparation we built together.

You're in contract!

Let's *bring it home*.

Your offer was accepted — this is really happening! Now it's a relay race of timing, paperwork, and people, and my job is to keep the momentum going while making it feel calm on your end. Here's what happens and what's on you.

THE ESCROW TIMELINE

● Day 1 – 3

DEPOSIT & INTRODUCTIONS

I connect you with the escrow officer and your loan agent. You wire your earnest-money deposit using instructions confirmed by phone — never from an email alone.

● Week 1 – 2

LOAN & APPRAISAL

Your lender orders the appraisal. The appraiser confirms the home's value supports your loan amount. I prepare comps to support the price.

● Week 2 – 3

CONDITIONS CLEARING

Loan approval, title cleared, insurance bound. I'm tracking every piece and keeping everyone on schedule.

● Week 3 – 4

FINAL STEPS

You sign closing documents, wire your remaining funds, and we do a final walkthrough. Then it records.

One rule for escrow: keep your finances boringly stable until we close. No big purchases, no new credit cards, no job changes if you can help it. Any of these can genuinely affect your loan approval.

WIRE FRAUD WARNING — READ THIS

Wire your deposit only using instructions you've confirmed with me by phone. Wire fraud is real and it targets buyers in exactly this window. If an email tells you the wiring account has changed — no matter how official it looks — assume it's a scam and call me first. Every single time.

THE APPRAISAL

If the appraisal comes in lower than your purchase price, it means the appraiser doesn't think the home is worth what you offered — and your lender won't cover the gap. We have options: renegotiate the price, cover the difference in cash, or in rare cases, walk. I'll have comps ready to support the value before the appraiser even shows up.

SECURE YOUR INSURANCE

You'll need homeowner's insurance locked in before closing — your lender requires proof of it. I'll introduce you to an insurance agent early so this doesn't become a last-minute scramble.

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Know the numbers — *no surprises.*

The purchase price is just the starting point. Before you close, and well after, there are costs that every buyer should understand. No surprises — here's what's on the list.

CLOSING COSTS — WHAT YOU PAY TO CLOSE

COST	WHAT IT IS
Title & escrow	In SF, the <i>buyer</i> customarily pays these — the escrow fee, title insurance, and recording fees. Budget roughly 1–1.5% of the purchase price.
Loan costs	Origination fees, discount points (if you buy down the rate), and lender-required items. Your lender will itemize these.
Prepaid items	Property tax proration, prepaid interest, and initial insurance premium — collected at closing to fund your escrow account.
Inspections	If you order additional inspections beyond the seller's pre-sale reports (e.g. a specialist look at the foundation or sewer lateral).

ONGOING COSTS — THE REAL MONTHLY NUMBER

- **Property tax** — roughly 1.2% of the purchase price annually in SF, paid in two installments. Your assessed value resets to the sale price at purchase.
- **Homeowner's insurance** — required by your lender, and a must regardless. Costs vary by property type, size, and coverage. Get quotes early.
- **HOA dues** — if you're buying a condo or TIC with a homeowners association. These cover building maintenance, insurance, and reserves — and they can range from a few hundred to well over a thousand a month.
- **Maintenance** — the rule of thumb is 1–2% of your home's value per year for upkeep. Older SF homes can run higher.

TALK TO YOUR LENDER & CPA

I'll give you the real-estate picture, but the tax implications and the loan math are conversations for your lender and your accountant. I'm not a tax advisor — loop them in early so there are no April surprises.

RUN THE NUMBERS YOURSELF

I built a **payment calculator** on my website so you can plug in a purchase price and see the real monthly picture — principal, interest, tax, insurance, HOA — before we even tour. Try it at claudiainsider.com.

Keys in hand — *you did it!*

The last stretch is mostly logistics — the deal is protected, now we land it cleanly. Escrow is the neutral third party holding funds and documents until every condition is met. Then it records, the money moves, and the home is officially yours.

BEFORE YOU GET THE KEYS

- **Final walkthrough** — we visit the home one last time to confirm it's in the condition you agreed to and that any negotiated repairs were done. Bring your eyes, not your measuring tape (that comes after).
- **Sign closing documents** — a stack of papers, but nothing you haven't seen before. I'll be there to walk you through anything that's unclear.
- **Wire your remaining funds** — using verified instructions, same protocol as your deposit. The escrow officer confirms the exact amount.
- **Recording** — the county records the deed in your name. This is the legal moment you own the home. Your agent gets the call, and I get to tell you it's yours.

SETTING UP YOUR NEW HOME

- **Utilities** — transfer PG&E (and CleanPowerSF), SFPUC water & sewer, and Recology for trash, recycling, and compost, effective your possession date.
- **Keys & codes** — collect every key, garage remote, gate code, alarm code, and smart-lock login from the seller.
- **Change your locks** — first day. You don't know who has copies.
- **Forward your mail** — file with USPS a couple of weeks before your move.

I'LL HAND YOU A STARTER KIT

My **Vendor Resource list** — locksmith, handyman, cleaners, the whole new-homeowner starter pack for SF. Plus new-address cards, because a little housewarming touch goes a long way.

You own a home in San Francisco! Let that land for a second. I'll handle the last logistics — you handle the couch delivery and the celebration.

A NOTE TO END ON

Buy it well, and *on your terms.*

Buying a home is a life event, not just a transaction. It usually sits on top of a move, a change, a new chapter — and it deserves someone who'll help you through it well rather than rush you through it.

If this guide did its job, you're a little less anxious and a lot more informed. That's the whole point — informed buyers make the calm, confident decisions that protect their money and match their life. When you're ready to start looking, no pressure and no clock, I'd love to be your insider.

claudia

BOOK A FREE 20-MIN CONSULT

claudia@vantagesanfrancisco.com · [@claudiainsider](https://www.instagram.com/claudiainsider)

Claudia Lee · REALTOR® · DRE #02380540 · Vantage Realty



claudia lee